



Chamber music

Music played in a small space, rather than a concert hall, is called chamber music. Unlike an orchestra, a chamber ensemble has no conductor and each player has an individual part to play. The most frequently heard chamber ensemble is a string quartet—two violins, a viola, and a cello—while the most popular wind group is a quintet of flute, oboe, clarinet, bassoon, and the French horn.

Wind octet

Pairs of oboes, clarinets, horns, and bassoons form a wind octet, also known as “Harmonie”—a favorite grouping for 18th-century chamber music.

Bassoons play
bass line
and harmony

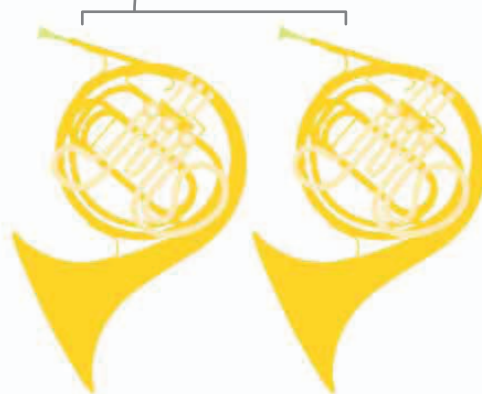
Oboes and clarinets play upper
notes, mainly melody

French horns
provide harmony

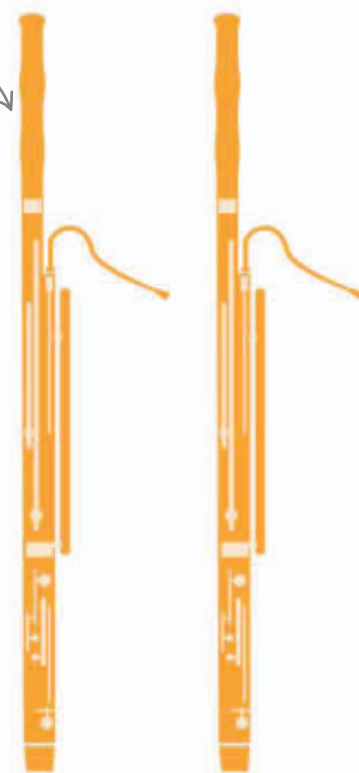


Oboes

Clarinets



French horns



Bassoons

Opera

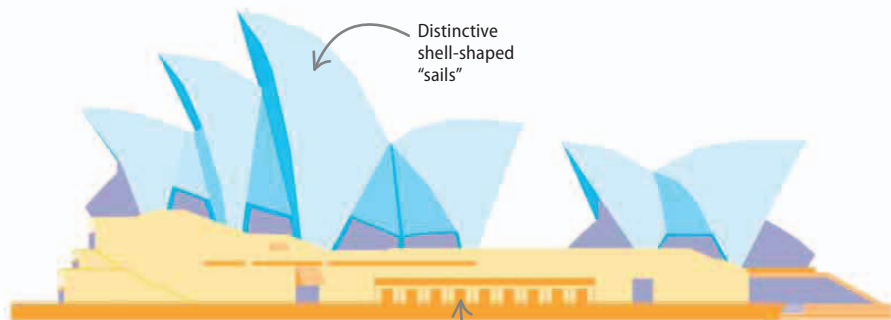
Dating from the 1600s, opera is a dramatic musical entertainment, with a plot, arias (songs), spoken or sung dialogue, ensembles, choruses, and instrumental numbers. Depending on the date of the opera, plots, characters, sets, and musical styles vary, but performances are known for their excitement, emotional drama, and musical virtuosity.

▽ Sydney Opera House

Most capital cities now have an opera house. Sydney's iconic opera house has various halls and hosts more than 1,500 performances each year.

Distinctive
shell-shaped
“sails”

The building contains the opera house,
two theaters, a concert hall, and studios.



REAL WORLD

Ballet

Ballet began in the Renaissance courts as a dance entertainment with musical accompaniment. Until the mid-19th century, music for ballet was not as important as the dance itself. Tchaikovsky (1840–93) elevated ballet music to an art form by writing ballet scores based on a story. His most famous examples are *The Nutcracker* and *Swan Lake*.

